TRAVEL GUIDE

Accommodation Guide

All-inclusive resorts, boutique hotels, private villas and budget stays - a practical breakdown to help you choose where to sleep.

Prepared for NotebookLM practice exercise - Unicorn University AI Software Development Course

The Dominican Republic has one of the widest lodging spectrums in the Caribbean - from US$40 guesthouses to US$3,000/night private villas. This guide breaks down what to expect at each level, what "all-inclusive" really means here, and how to pick the right base for your trip style.

1. All-inclusive resorts (the dominant model)

Roughly **70% of foreign visitors** stay at all-inclusive resorts, concentrated in Punta Cana/Bavaro, Puerto Plata, and Bayahibe. A single per-person nightly rate typically covers:

- Room and all meals (buffets + several a la carte restaurants).
- Domestic and often premium liquor.
- Non-motorized watersports (kayaks, paddleboards, snorkeling gear).
- Entertainment (nightly shows, kids' clubs, live music).
- Some resorts include unlimited golf, spa credits, or free excursions.

What is usually NOT included:

- Airport transfers (unless booked as a package with a tour operator).
- Motorized watersports (jet ski, parasailing).
- Off-property excursions.
- Premium dining experiences (chef's table, in-suite dinner).
- WiFi in some older properties (still surprisingly common).
- Tips beyond the resort's standard service charge.

Tiers and typical price bands (per night for two, high season)

Tier	Example brands	Rate range (US$)
Budget	Bahia Principe (basic), Riu Naiboa, Whala!Bavaro	140-220
Mid-tier	Iberostar Selection, Grand Palladium, Barcelo Bavaro Palace	250-400
Upscale	Melia Caribe, Hard Rock Punta Cana, Dreams Royal Beach	400-650
Luxury / adults-only	Excellence, Secrets, Zoëtry Agua, Sanctuary Cap Cana	650-1,200
Ultra-luxury	Eden Roc Cap Cana, Casa de Campo, Amanera	1,200-3,500

Choosing the right resort

Ask these before booking:

1. **Is it adults-only or family-friendly?** Melia "The Level", Bahia Principe "Luxury", and any resort with "Adults" or "Secrets" in the name filter kids out.
2. **What is the beach like at low tide?** Some Bavaro beaches lose 30 m of sand at low tide. Read recent reviews.
3. **Is seaweed (sargassum) a problem?** March-October brings intermittent sargassum. Resorts with active daily cleanup (Melia, Iberostar, Hard Rock) are safer bets.
4. **How many a la carte restaurants and are reservations required?** Below 4 restaurants for a 7-night stay = repetitive buffet.

5. **Are drinks premium?** Some budget resorts pour only local rum and reconstituted juices.
6. **Airport distance?** Beyond 40 minutes from PUJ, transfers cut into your beach time.

2. Boutique hotels

The Dominican Republic has a growing boutique-hotel scene, especially in **Las Terrenas, Cabarete, Santo Domingo Zona Colonial, and Las Galeras**. These are typically 8-40 rooms, often owner-operated, with strong food, personal service, and design character.

Sample properties:

- **Peninsula House** (Las Terrenas) - 6-suite mansion, Relais & Chateaux tier, ~US$900/night.
- **Sublime Samana** (Las Terrenas) - condo-hotel with beach, spa, jazz nights.
- **Billini Hotel** (Zona Colonial) - restored 16th-century convent, ~US$250/night.
- **Casa Bonita** (Barahona) - mountain-view eco-boutique.
- **Natura Cabana** (Cabarete) - thatched-roof beachside cabanas.

Boutiques generally do **not** include meals in the rate. Budget an extra US$50-100 per person per day for food and drink.

3. Villas and rentals

Independent villas are very common on the north coast (Cabrera, Rio San Juan), in Cap Cana, in Casa de Campo, and along the Samana Peninsula. Options include:

- **Airbnb / VRBO** - the fastest-growing segment. Well-regulated. Beach condos in Bavaro from US$120/night; luxury villas from US$800-5,000/night.
- **Villa rentals through resorts** - Casa de Campo and Cap Cana have private-villa programs with resort access. Expect US$1,500-8,000/night for 3-7 bedrooms.
- **Private-owner villas via agents** - Sotheby's, Casa Vacation, Villas del Mar.

Pros: More space, private pool, kitchen, sometimes staff (cook, housekeeper). Better value for groups of 4+. **Cons:** No resort restaurants or bars on site; need to organize groceries, transport, and activities separately.

4. Guesthouses, hostels, and budget stays

- **Cabarete** - surfer-friendly hostels from US$20/dorm bed.
- **Las Galeras and Las Terrenas** - small pensiones from US$50/night.
- **Santo Domingo** - Zona Colonial has cheap guesthouses (US$40-80).

Budget travelers should factor in transport and meals - with the country's food and transit relatively cheap, a good rhythm is US$40-60/day plus lodging.

5. Airbnb and rental logistics

- Rentals in gated resort communities (Casa de Campo, Cap Cana, Los Corales) often require an extra "guest pass" fee at the gate.
- Confirm whether **WiFi and A/C** are included and reliable - power cuts still happen outside

resorts; ask about a generator or inverter.

- Some rental owners require a **damage deposit** in cash on arrival.

6. What to look for in reviews

- Consistent recent mentions of **friendly, well-trained staff** - the single biggest predictor of guest satisfaction.
- Beach quality **year-round**, not just in December.
- Mention of **water pressure and reliable hot water** - a surprising weak point at older Dominican hotels.
- If you value quiet, filter reviews for words like "music", "loud", "shows" - some resorts play amplified music by the pool 10:00-22:00.
- For food: look for the phrase **"variety"** - most complaints in this country's resort reviews trace back to repetitive buffets rather than bad cooking.

7. Booking tips

- **High season** (mid-Dec to mid-Apr): Book 4-6 months ahead for the best resorts.
- **Christmas and New Year week**: Rates 40-80% higher, and best rooms sell out 8 months out.
- Shoulder-season deals appear in **May, September, and early December**. All-inclusive rates can drop 40%.
- **Package deals** with charter airlines (TUI, Condor, Air Transat, Sunwing) are often 20-35% cheaper than booking flight and hotel separately.
- Consider **7-night stays**: many resorts price 7 nights lower per-night than 5.

8. A note on tipping and service charge at hotels

The Dominican Republic legally imposes an **18% ITBIS tax** and a **10% service charge** on hotel and restaurant bills. All-inclusive resort rates already include these. Housekeeping, bartenders, waitstaff, and bellmen appreciate small daily cash tips (US$1-5) - most work for tips as a significant portion of income.